

Unjust Religion as Fiction

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1 Working Papers 2026 – Status Dashboard

Current status as of `r format(Sys.Date(), '%B %Y')`

1.1 Active Papers

Manticore

- ☐ Literature Review
- ☐ Primary texts read & noted
- ☐ Brainstorm Core Argument
- ☐ Draft paper outline with main sections
- ☐ Write first draft
- ☐ Share draft with trusted colleagues
- ☐ Identify possible objections
- ☐ Research Relevant Conferences
- ☐ Research target journals for submission
- ☐ Objections section started
- ☐ Responses to objections
- ☐ Submit to journal X by end of Q2

The Aesthetic Problem of Evil

- ☐ Literature Review
- ☐ Primary texts read & noted
- ☐ Brainstorm Core Argument
- ☐ Draft paper outline with main sections
- ☐ Write first draft
- ☐ Share draft with trusted colleagues
- ☐ Identify possible objections
- ☐ Research Relevant Conferences
- ☐ Research target journals for submission
- ☐ Objections section started
- ☐ Responses to objections

- ☐ Submit to journal X by end of Q2

1.1.1 Morality as Privilege

- ☐ Literature Review
- ☐ Primary texts read & noted
- ☐ Brainstorm Core Argument
- ☐ Draft paper outline with main sections
- ☐ Write first draft
- ☐ Share draft with trusted colleagues
- ☐ Identify possible objections
- ☐ Research Relevant Conferences
- ☐ Research target journals for submission
- ☐ Objections section started
- ☐ Responses to objections
- ☐ Submit to journal X by end of Q2

1.1.2 God as the Best Possible Epistemic Ground of Human Dignity

- ☐ Literature Review
 - ☐ Imago Dei as Human Identity by Ryan Peterson
- ☐ Primary texts read & noted
- ☐ Brainstorm Core Argument
- ☐ Draft paper outline with main sections
- ☐ Write first draft
- ☐ Share draft with trusted colleagues
- ☐ Identify possible objections
- ☐ Research Relevant Conferences
- ☐ Research target journals for submission
- ☐ Objections section started
- ☐ Responses to objections
- ☐ Submit to journal X by end of Q2

1.2 Next Up

- [Aesthetics of Evil](#)

Part I

Active Papers

2 Aesthetics of Evil

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2.1 Abstract

In medieval bestiaries, there are two classes of evil represented by beasts; those which deceive and those which generate fear and death. Among the first class of beasts, those which are notable for their abilities to deceive, there are three kinds of deception: these are noted by the camouflages of the chameleon, accurate imitations of the manticore, and the “seductive skills of sirens”.

- **Deceivers:** Camouflage, imitation, seduction
 - Chameleon: camouflage
 - Manticore: accurate imitations
 - Sirens: seductive skills
- **Fear and Death Generators**

While we might think this to be a medieval taxonomy of epistemic harms only, the kinds of epistemic harms the medievalists worried about are not far off from contemporary epistemic harms and risks; misinformation, false and inauthentic narratives, and bullsh*t. This article looks at those beasts which represent epistemic harms and attempts to develop an account of inauthentic narrative as a moral harm.

On some accounts, the manticore is a union between a hyena and Ethiopian lioness. It imitates the voices of men and possesses a fixed and immovable gaze. In addition, it does not possess gums in either of its jaws, and rather than having multiple teeth, it has one large one that curves around its jaw bone.

Pliny the elder is one who describes the manticore as a union between an Ethiopian lioness and hyaena. Two notoriously deadly enemies who fight for the same for supplies across the African plain. The fact that he draws emphasis on the fact that the hyaena is male while the lioness is female suggests that the manticore is born from a procreative union between the two, and not

merely a creative one. Perhaps the manticore has obtained its ability to speak from the male hyaena's ability to imitate the voice of a man. Pliny tells us that the hyaena is able to learn a man's name, so that in calling him away from the protection of his home, can then devour him. It appears that the manticore too possesses this ability, and not only of men, but can imitate the voices of cattle in addition. Like Aristotle, Pliny claims that the manticore does not possess gums in either of its jaws and that its teeth are one continuous piece of bone.

Ctesias' description includes that the Manticore had a triple row of teeth which fit into each other like a comb, the face and ears of a human, blood colored eyes, the body of a lion and a stinging tail similar to a scorpion. While Pliny the elder argued that it imitated the voices of men, Ctesias tells us that its voice resembles a union of a flute and trumpet, that it is exceedingly swift, and has an appetite for human flesh [p. 280].

Aristotle questions Ctesias' account, but nevertheless preserves it in his own writings. He also reproduces Ctesias' account, that the Manticore possesses a double rather than triple row of teeth, has similar feet as a lion and is similar in size to a lion. What is perhaps important are the anthropomorphic descriptions including those of the ears and face of a human, and that it has non-anthropomorphic ones such as grey eyes and red body and possesses a tail like that of a scorpion. [p. 30-31; also see Aristotle, *History of Animals* 8.28, 605b22-606a10]

When we talk about aesthetic function, it is often not an animal's status as real or imaginary that is a central feature of the animal's inclusion. Rather, the animal's inclusion into the bestiary is an aesthetic function. However, it would not be entirely accurate to say that this function did not possess any truth values. On the one hand, it may be tempting to say that the value of the animal's inclusion is a symbolic gesture. But often times the inclusion had Christological purposes, such as the representation of some important religious derivation.

There is a stark division in the kinds of reflections these involved as some animals represented Christian reflections of salvation whereas others represented threats to salvation. One such example includes images of a lion breathing on his dead cub and after three days revive them just as Christ died on the cross and rose after three days (Morrison and Grollemond 2019, 4). Another point of stark contrast included animals as the representation of either virtues or vices that are thought to be common to human experience. A dragon who could kill elephants by smothering them with its tail is one such example.

There are several ways in which some art objects may represent more complex realities. One may think that the purpose of a painting is to reflect the experiences one had during a war, or peace time event. Such a painting may express the given facts of the case, for instance an artist could paint the signing of the Magna Carta.

If the painting were painted by an artist who was alive to witness the signing of the Magna Carta, then the artist would merely be representing contemporary reality. If the artist were not alive at the time, then we could argue that the artist is representing historical reality. The artist is relying on trusted and well known sources would be different from the artist imagining an event in which not many direct sources exist. But an artist can represent a projection of

reality as well when the reality they want to convey is obscure, not well known, highly contested or hypothetical.

Moral (2021) argues that art's purpose in the middle ages is to represent reality. It is one thing to accurately and factually represent a tree, however, Pinero is talking about more complex reality, especially moral reality. One example of medieval representations of moral reality include the Persian Manticore. The manticore as depicted in medieval art is said to represent evil.

According to this definition of medieval art, art implies metaphysical aspirations and normative elements (Also see De Bruyne 1959). Its commitment to reality is undeniable, yet the reality which it attempts to represent is so complex and vast that the limits between what is and what is not, between what we believe and what we know, between what we are and what we wish to be, are often blurred (cron41?).

Here, the artist can represent facts as they believe them to be, or as they wish them to be. It is this latter motivation that Pinero suggests motivated medieval artwork representing the manticore. There is a difference here then between modern and medieval artistic function. This in itself is uninteresting. However, what may be more interesting to the reader, is the further claim that this difference can be applied in response to the contemporary account of epistemic injustice.

Owing to the fantastical nature of these accounts, it is highly probable that they are either misguided representations of some more familiar animal, or motivated by purposes other than truth. In the classical era, it is most likely the case that the Manticore is a confused representation of some other more familiar animal, while in the medieval period, the motivation for the representation lies outside of truth.

We might think that medieval art has no place in a discussion about epistemic injustice, but the depiction of the fictional beast called the manticore, as a personification of deception lends credibility to the claim that medieval art is an early representation of the dangers of epistemic harms. According to the modern function of art summed up by Gilmore (2020), art's function is oriented to ends such as pleasure, entertainment, and absorption [132]. Conversely, the medieval function of art is directed at more orthodox ends intending to motivate positive emotion states, or desirable behaviors and behavioral responses.

According to some hermeneutic views centering on epistemic injustice, because of a misappropriated power imbalance, a person holds false beliefs about themselves. These beliefs stem from unjust environments where the individual lacks access to resources that would lead to accurate self-understanding and moral beliefs. Such beliefs are rooted in irrational actions performed by that individual.

One such concept of hermeneutic justice has been popularized by Miranda Fricker (2007) though it was also developed by earlier feminists. As an artistic object, the Manticore is a fictionalized beast that was born in Persian art and literature sometime around its cultural

zenith. It at once symbolizes evil, death and hell, but in medieval religious art, it had come to symbolize the power of Christ over death and hell.

3 Currie's Fiction

Why do we think that fairy tales are fiction but news stories are not? Is fake news the same thing as a fairy tale? During the pandemic, fake news became a widely discussed talking point. A less widely discussed talking point however was why don't we just call it fiction? A derivative of this question is how fiction is made possible. Meaning, what are the creative differences between fake news, news news and fairy tales? To answer this question, Gregory Currie (1990) suggests three possible answers.

According to the front page news, the terrorist leader Amelia Boyd was killed by the Headhunters Gang. First are the characteristics that distinguish fiction from non-fiction. This question is a close investigation of the entities that are in fiction and make them possible. For instance, the psychological and linguistic resources that producers and consumers of fiction must have access to.

First, consider that fiction uses language. But there is no universal linguistic feature shared by all fictional works and there is no available proof/s confirming what is a fiction. We usually think that reading a work is an act of reading words and sentences that make it up.² However, consider a mime? Or silent films? These are works that do not use language in the traditional sense, yet we consider them fictional. Therefore, what makes something a fiction cannot necessarily be a linguistic feature. Therefore what makes something a fiction is neither a necessary nor sufficient condition for being fictional. Finally then, something can be a fiction because of its verbal structure, but what makes it a fiction does not lie in the text itself.

3.1 Semantic Properties

Currie concludes that fictionality is a relational property, it is something possessed in virtue of the text's relations to other things. Therefore while it is possible that fictionality is a linguistic matter, what makes it a fiction lies in some other property. (a method of communication or other communicative practice)

On this account, fictional properties, like non-fictional ones, have the semantic properties of truth value and reference. What this means is that a fictional statement can be true and false. For instance, consider the statement "Killing an NPC in monitored space will earn you a crime state". According to Currie, this statement is true. What makes something true or false in a fiction, is its relation to the outside world and so what is important then, is what this relationship is.

Because fiction is a relational property, they are community based and “depend on the prevailing attitudes of the community, or of a subgroup of the community rather than the ideas of a single individual” (Currie 1990, 10).

For I take it that an act of joint authorship is exactly that: an act engaged in by more than one person rather than several distinct acts undertaken individually and patched together. (Currie 1990, 11)

The process of creating a fiction begins with the intention. It is not a singular intention however, but is a social enterprise. So maybe the reason that we do not call fake news, fiction, is because of the purposes and intent of fake news. It is intended to deceive rather than express true propositions. But if this is true, then why do we not consider that fiction is intended to deceive? Why does fiction have semantic properties such as truth whereas fake news does not? Currie (1990)

Owing to the fantastical nature of these accounts, it is highly probable that they are either misguided or motivated by some purposes other than truth. In the 57th question of the 1st of the second part of the *Summa Theologica*, Thomas Aquinas defends the view of art as a form of right reason. There is a distinction here between the right reason for making objects, and the right reason for doing good actions. We should first focus on the point that is important to both of these activities, is the right use of one’s cognitive faculties. The difference lies in the produced object, whether an action or thing.

If we are to ask ourselves what justifies our emotional responses to some given experience, on the one hand we might consider that the validity of the experience rests in something like the authenticity of the experience. Assuming that artistic experiences are driven by the same norms as other experiences, the image of the Manticore would generate fear in those who were lucky enough to witness an artistic representation of one, whether literary or visual. However, artistic experiences are not always governed by the same norms as other kinds of experiences. Some additional norms that govern our experiences with fiction include pleasure, entertainment, and absorption (Gilmore 2020, 132). However, this would mark an important divergence from the functions of art accepted by the medievalist, and those accepted by us today.

Considering a product that is produced, the desired outcome of the activity of art, it is not clear what it is exactly, that we care about in the case of art. When it comes to what is produced in the case of art, it is not clear whether the final thing produced is an action, or a material commodity. The common contemporary understanding considers various perspectives. However, it is important to understand two important points here.

Moral (2021) argues that this is because art’s purpose in the middle ages is to represent reality. It is one thing to accurately and factually represent a tree, however, Pinero is talking about more complex reality, especially moral reality. One example of medieval representations of moral reality include the Persian Manticore. The manticore as depicted in medieval art is said to represent evil.

There are several ways in which some art objects may represent more complex realities. One may think that the purpose of a painting is to reflect the experiences one had during a war, or peace time event. Such a painting may express the given facts of the case, for instance an artist could paint the signing of the Magna Carta. If the painting were painted by an artist who was alive to witness the signing of the Magna Carta, then the artist would merely be representing contemporary reality. If the art were not alive at the time, then we could argue that the artist is representing historical reality. If the artist is relying on trusted sources that are well-known, then this would be different than if the artist were imagining an event in which not many direct sources exist. But an artist can represent a projection of reality as well when the reality they want to convey is obscure, not well known, highly contested etc.

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The difference lies in the produced object, whether an action or thing. But here, we should pause momentarily or we risk conflating two senses of right action. In the ancient context,

right action would more probably be used to reference actions that align with a dominant organizational structure, for instance the Catholic church. In our own modern context, we are less apt to recognize a singular dominant moral authority. This presents a problem since we would want to say something more akin to ‘beneficial’, or ‘productive’ action where ‘benefit’ and ‘product’ are more expressive of individual tastes and desires.

Considering a product that is produced, the desired outcome of the activity of art, it is not clear what it is exactly, that we collectively care about in the case of art then. When it comes to what is produced by artistic endeavor, it is not clear whether a normative account should include a material commodity, or a desired outcome apart from a material commodity. When we think about what a good artistic endeavor entails, in the modern conception, there is typically some monetary component. For instance, an admirable artistic endeavor at the center of an advertising campaign would ideally result in increased revenue for the advertising clients and increased business for the advertiser.

However, the medieval conception of an admirable artistic endeavor consists of outcomes which invoke some kind of behavior. Whether dispositions or actions, ultimately there is a desire for an intended outcome as it correlates specifically with a human actor. Harrison (2011) argues for instance, that Elizabeth Gaskell’s novel *Mary Barton: A Tale of Manchester Life* was in part responsible for the UK’s expanded social safety net. Gaskell represented the suffering and distress experienced by the working poor in a way that allowed her upper-class Victorian audience to empathize with the lower social classes (Harrison 2011, 258). For instance, we might think that a good artist produces items of great monetary value. But using the medieval depiction as expressed above, it seems that a good artist instead motivates an actor to behave in a way that produces good outcomes. The common contemporary understanding considers various perspectives. However, it is important to understand the two important points here.

It is this distinctive kind of epistemic harm/injustice that consists of undermining our ability to convey knowledge to others and make sense of our own experiences (Fricker 2007).

Susan Pepper-Gates in a forth-coming paper writes a very engaging and important paper article applying Miranda Fricker (2007)’s analysis of epistemic injustice to contemporary Western Religion WR, and the Philosophy of Religion, PoWR. She argues that the philosophy of religion should cultivate epistemic-ethical virtues in order to recognize and include philosophers from minority voices. Doing so helps WR and PoWR understand and recognize the ways that power shapes our lives as embodied social beings.

I think that the initial conclusion is a strong one. Namely the ways that power shapes our lives as embodied social beings is important for concepts that we associate with who we are. However, I think that the most important conclusion here is a premise conclusion statement. Rather than WR and PoWR cultivating epistemic virtues, WR and PoWR should focus on the cultivation of epistemic virtues, meaning that they should focus on how epistemic virtue is created. This will give the project of WR and PoWR two convergent aims.

1. First, it would be to draw attention to the ways in which power *can* shape our lives as embodied social beings.
2. Cultivating virtue in this context then, means that WR and PoWR ought be formative, cultivating virtue in their audiences.
3. However, possessing virtue in this sense, makes it less likely that power will shape the lives of WR and PoWR's audiences.

3.2 Some Questions

A central question here is one of difference in kinds of harm. Specifically what kind of harm is being done. Additionally, is the kind of harm that we care about adjudicated solely in virtue of racial, or ethnic distinctiveness?

3.3 Peppers-Gates Analysis of Fricker

Peppers-Gates first points out that Western Religion, WR, and The Philosophy of Western Religion, PoWR, have historically ignored work by intersectional feminist philosophers and philosophers of race who challenge the traditional approach. However, how is this done? First, traditional epistemology, TE, focuses on abstract universal knowledge while the philosophy of religion has traditionally grounded itself in TE by focusing on rational belief.

In order for the philosophy of religion to cultivate epistemic-ethical virtues, it should recognize and include philosophers from minority voices. Peppers-Gates argument takes the following form:

1. Traditional epistemology focuses on abstract universal knowledge.
2. Philosophy of religion grounds itself in traditional epistemology and focuses on rational belief.
3. Therefore WR and PoWR embrace narrow methodologies that exclude others and contributes to the marginalization of minority voices.
4. Given its focus on abstract universal knowledge and its marginalization of minority voices, WR and PoWR ignore work by intersectional feminist philosophers and philosophers of race who challenge the traditional approach and argue that power shapes our lives as embodied social beings.
5. As such, WR and PoWR conflate the truth about the existence and attributes of a [pateriachal] God with traditional epistemic approaches grounded in [narrow methological approaches to knowledge].
6. By focusing on narrow methodologies and abstract conceptions of knowledge, WR and PoWR fail to consider ways that power shapes our lives as embodied social beings.

A central point in the above argument is that WR and PoWR have silenced marginalized groups. These include women, people of color, disabled persons and members of the LGBTQI+ community. As stated above, the reason for this is because traditional epistemology focuses on abstract conceptions of knowledge and thereby fails to consider the ways that power shapes our lives as embodied social beings. We might think however, that the argument rests on a notion of rules bias. Namely that by using certain conversational rules in philosophical discourse, that PoWR and WR silence minority groups due to their falling in some way to abide by these rules of discourse.

To see how this is the case, we can use the grammar contrast. Here, we assume that a person can learn grammar and we exclude them from the larger conversation until they do. But this would be an unfair response to the above argument. On the one hand, we could argue that it is grounded in a misreading of the argument, that minority voices are excluded from the philosophical lexicon not because they have failed to abide by the rules of philosophical discourse, but because either 1) their topics of concern fall outside the margin of interest, or 2) because of some varying identifying physical characteristic, such as failure to develop a 'rational' argument as determined by the implied narrow rules of discourse. But this would be a misrepresentation of the above argument.

The way I understand Peppers-Gates argument, is that marginalized groups have been excluded from philosophical discourse because of certain hermeneutic challenges, namely the way they are *understood* as having failed to abide by the rules of philosophical discourse. Therefore, we can amend the above argument in the following way:

1. TE focuses on abstract conceptions of knowledge.
2. PoWR grounds itself in TE by focusing on 'rational' belief in its debates about God's existence and attributes.
3. Therefore PoWR ignores feminist philosophers and philosophers of race who challenge PoWR's rules which are grounded in TE.
4. As such, WR and PoWR have silenced marginal groups.
5. PoWR's embrace of its narrow methodology and range of topics then is based in an exclusion of 'others' from meaning making in institutional philosophy.

The final premise then says that the narrow methodology employed by PoWR is not a natural methodology, but is rather exclusive in its construction. Meaning that it is narrow specifically for the purposes of excluding minority views and opinions within the lexicon. As such, I understand that the paper defends the following conclusion:

The Philosophy of Western Religion focuses on rational belief and conflates this with evolving and misapplied lexical rules in its debates about the existence and attributes of a patriarchal God.

3.4 Silencing

Western religion and the philosophy of religion have silenced marginalized groups by focusing on abstract conceptions of knowledge which fail to consider ways that power shapes our lives as embodied social beings. This is because traditional epistemology focuses on abstract conceptions of knowledge. These abstract conceptions of knowledge are inadequate because they do not analyze the ways power shapes our lives as “embodied social beings”. We are born in webs of meaning and social relations of power and privilege. Some voices are heard, meaning they pass review, and therefore shape the social imagination. Others are ignored however. These others then are incapable of shaping the social imagination.

On the one hand, a defense of the traditional power structure would make sure to emphasize what it means to participate in the sort of debate that does have the potential to shape the social imagination. How is one’s voice heard? One way is through the enforcement of so-called grammar rules. Taking an art class, the professor attempts to communicate the rules which apply to a given art genre. However, the students note the many deviations from these rules, the supposed exceptions. The professor then replies by saying that “once you know how to apply the rules, then you are allowed to break the rules”. An imagined analogy would be a reviewer rejecting a paper for the alleged abuse of grammar rules that a more seasoned author would be allowed to bend. A concern here is one where the so-called rules are being inappropriately applied as a means of gate-keeping who gets to shape the ‘social-imagination’. A student who fails to learn the rules, is not accepted into the art community, where work is posted in galleries, sold at auctions, is not publicly (positively or negatively) reviewed etc,. Of additional importance here, is that assuming a more seasoned author is justified in bending the lexical rules of philosophical discourse, than the more seasoned author can also be seen as contributing to the development of the lexicon rules surrounding philosophical discourse. As such, the more seasoned professional is allowed to shape the rules of discourse, and thereby contribute to the social imagination.

As such, the harm which ought to concern us here includes the exclusion of individuals from the generally shared social understanding. Excluding voices in this way contributes to their harm or can be used as a weapon to harm individual. But what is this weapon and how specifically does it as a weapon cause harm? In the following section, I will show how participation in the shared lexical structure has been called a marker of humanity. Therefore gatekeepers undermine the process by which a person becomes human.

3.5 Hermeneutic Injustice

1. When DSS (Dominant Social Structure) of meaning exclude you or distort your experiences, and no social concepts that you recognize capture your vision of yourself, then your capacity as a knower and your own self-understanding have been stunted.

1. But this introduces a very narrow vision of social structure. Isn't it possible that while you are excluded from a dss, a non-dss, one that includes you and does not distort your experiences, could still capture a vision of yourself, and your capacity as a knower and fortifying your self-understanding.
2. What is needed then is a new non-dss, education.
3. While a person is excluded from a dss, they could have their capacity as a knower fortified by a non-dss, education reimagined.

The need to reimagine education.

1. WR and PoR become DSS's of meaning and exclude some or distort their experiences
2. But this introduces a very narrow vision of social structure.
 1. It is possible that while you are excluded from a dss, a non-dss, one that includes you and does not distort your experiences, could still capture a vision of yourself, and your capacity as a knower and fortifying your self-understanding.
 2. So while a person is excluded from a dss, they could have their capacity as a knower fortified by a non-dss.
3. Therefore 2 this does not mean that there are no social concepts that you recognize and capture your vision of yourself and your capacity as a knower and your own self-understanding are stunted but not by the DSS, but the lack of the non-dss.

3.5.1 One Possible example of hermeneutic injustice against religious minorities

Secular community marginalization against people of religious faith.

1. PoRF may lack 'sensibilities and resources needed to make sense of religious people's experiences," (Kidd, 20217).
2. But does not capture gravity of systemic cases of hermeneutical injustice whose targets experience multiple forms of injustice.
 1. Hermeneutical marginalization "entails marginalization of a socioeconomic sort', targets will not 'participate on equal terms within the practices of law, academia, politics, religion, journalism, media, etc. (Fricker, 2010).
 2. However, DSS vs. non-DSS? While DSS of meaning may distort experiences, non-dss may not, instead rejecting dss of meaning which says that "there are no social concepts which capture a religious person's vision of themselves (i.e., made in image of God, human dignity bestowed by God, not DSS, etc.)". Consider the following claims:
 3. Here, Fricker, a published philosopher, the DSS, says persons of a certain sort are marginalized and therefore have been silenced. But here, marginalization means they lack a marker of humanity. As such, Fricker claims that certain individuals lack a marker of humanity.

4. Why? For not adhering to rules of rationality practiced by the dss. Surely they could however do so?
5. Because of 1, they lack participation in shared meaning.
6. Therefore lack capacity as knowers.
7. From 3, their self-understanding is mitigated and stunted.
8. Participation in shared hermeneutic, i.e., 1-4, in shared conceptual structure is a marker of humanity”,
9. Therefore, because of exclusion from shared conceptual structure, they lack a marker of humanity.

but rather than ‘victims’ being excluded from shared conceptual structure and lacking capacity as knowers and lacking marker of humanity, they instead are included in different conceptual structure (e.g., religious conceptual structure) which fortifies their capacity as knowers and self-understanding, acting as marker of humanity.

4 On Greek Tragedy

4.1 Three Kinds of Tragic Conflict

1. Good people being ruined because of things that just happen to them, things they do not control.
2. Good people doing bad things, things opposite of their ethical character and commitments because of things they do not control.
3. Good people doing bad things without direct physical compulsion and opposite of their ethical character and commitments though done in light of circumstances of equally bad choices.

Agammenon is waiting on the shore with his entire fleet. He intends to carry out a directive from Zeus to avenge his brother whose wife ran away with Paris, prince of Troy. However, because of an earlier transgression against Artemis, Artemis is holding back the wind, stranding his fleet. Agammenon, as the result of an omen of an eagle devouring a hare, is told that in order to appease Artemis, he must sacrifice his daughter Iphigenia.

As such, Agammenon is faced with two impossible choices, fail to carry out Zeus's command, or kill his daughter. It is important to point out that the fleet is already facing starvation being stranded on the coast. However, Agammenon's sin, is not that he chooses sacrificing his daughter, instead it is the way he sacrificed his daughter.

- Like in the biblical story of Abraham, a good man must kill an innocent child "out of obedience to a divine command" [35].
- Agammenon's sin however, is not the choice, but rather how the choice was made:
 - Agammenon now begins to cooperate inwardly with necessity, arranging his feelings to accord with his fortune.
 - From the moment he makes his decision, itself the best he could have made, he strangely turns himself into a collaborator, a willing victim [35].

Progression of loss of agency:

- Necessity of the act
- to the rightness of the act
- to the rightness of the feelings of the act

In another paper, I highlighted some concerns raised by Wendy Laybourn (2018) regarding representation and authenticity. Here, I want to draw attention to some additional similar concerns. What is important here, is that these criticisms unfairly focus too narrowly on the black experience and do not do a good enough job in recognizing that these experiences are universal. Given their universality, I argue that a best response is found in a Christian theodicy to evil as a form of suffering.

Laybourn (2018)'s a criticism of black authenticity and what she calls commodified realness is a commodified identity that is sold to a broader public as black authenticity. This criticism is centered around the effects of what she calls controlling images in popular media. Of deep concern here, is that many of the members of the communities depicted by such images consider aspects of these images to be authentic representations and not in themselves harmful. Yet too, this is also a common trope.

I present this case as an example of a paradigmatic concept of hermeneutic injustice. It is not clear just what aspects of the member's lives are represented, nor specifically which images are harmful if such images are accepted as representative. An important question here has to do with the relationship between popular narratives that contain these images, and personal identity. One approach argues that we are defined by the stories we accept about ourselves, but this is controversial and it is the point I will address.

4.1.1 Wendy Laybourn's Cost of Being Real

Wendy Laybourn (2018) draws a comparison between black authenticity and what she calls commodified realness. According to Laybourn, identity is sold to a broader public as black authenticity. This criticism is centered around the effects of what she calls *controlling images* in popular media. Of deep concern here, is that many of the members of the communities depicted by such images, consider aspects of these images to be authentic representations of themselves and the communities in which they live. Therefore, there is a public perception that such images are not in themselves harmful. If they are in some degree controlling, then they would be harmful, but there is strong disagreement regarding whether or not they are (20C History Project 2014; Collins 2006, 2009; Sartwell 1998).

5 Patricia Collins Black Feminist Thought

In the 2009 version of Collin's Black Feminist Thought, BFT, Collins draws greater emphasis between relationships of knowledge and power. It is often said

- that knowledge = power,

but a worrying theme throughout the book, is that this is wrong and that rather

- power = knowledge.

One might notice the misapplication of a logical principle here, because whenever we use the equals sign, there is not a logical difference between $\text{power} = \text{knowledge}$ and $\text{knowledge} = \text{power}$.

Rather, this says that power is identical in value to knowledge and if power is identical to knowledge, then knowledge is identical to power.

In other words, the initial application claims that the direction of fit is not directional but rather than uni- or bi-directional.

For instance, we could look at some possible relationships between knowledge and power below:

- knowledge $\rightarrow$ power

or

- power $\rightarrow$ knowledge

or

- knowledge $\leftrightarrow$ power

Initially, we might think that assuming that if one has knowledge then the correct state of affairs should be that they will fulfill their aims, whatever those may be. This is often a selling point for higher education.

This is a common position in what is lauded as "African American Studies". Often times these positions are wrapped in the language of "struggle". While Collins notes that this "struggle" is a struggle for empowerment, it is not particularly clear who the struggle is directed at. She

argues that the struggle is global and transcendent, and she defines it as one for “survival.” But she expands the target in the most recent edition of her book to include recent developments in the areas of sexuality and “sexual politics” of black womanhood.

Some similar examples of this criticism can be found in Zakiyyah Iman Jackson (2020) or Mbembe (2017)’s *Critique of Black Reason*. Jackson (2020) defends the view of race as a social construct. Here black represents a void of reason and a surplus of animality. It is not clear what the counter to this claim should be as it is not represented anywhere in either work. However, looking at what is deemed black culture broadly in popular media, this counter claim is even more difficult to understand given that many African Americans fail to explicitly and publicly criticize, or at the very least, argue that such behaviors are not culturally representative.

Popular artists who reflect similar characteristics as those deemed synonymous to the black race are praised and vaunted. Black female artists for instance, who reinforce stereotypes of blacks as hypersexualized, vulgar, using codes such as twerking to exemplify their over hyper-sexualized nature, are praised as empowering or authentic, where as black male artists are praised as being “real” or “gritty” for expressing unjustified violence directed at other blacks. But this is just to mimic the age old racist justifications for slavery although slavery, in name, has been outlawed. According to this justification, blackness represents a blurred distinction between human and animal.

Man distinguishes himself from animality, but this is not the case for the Black Man, who maintains within himself, albeit with a certain degree of ambiguity, animal possibility. A foreign body in our world, he is inhabited under cover—by the animal. To debate Black reason is therefore to return to the collection of debates regarding the rules of how to define the Black Man: how he is recognized, how one identifies the animal spirit that possesses him, under which conditions the ratio penetrates and governs the animalitas. (Mbembe 2017, 56)

It is not necessarily clear where to find the literature on specifically what is at issue here. Because of this, I think it will be helpful to start with something of an analogy, specifically one from the popular narrative. In the newest *Wicked* screen adaptation, there is an underlying story line. The protagonist, the ‘wicked’ witch finally comes to accept that she will never be accepted by the broader public and as such, will always stand out as a scapegoat of sorts owing to her dark green skin. Therefore she fully leans into her ‘wicked’ persona.

However, perhaps a detail which could not be included as prominently in Gregory Maguire’s 1995 novel. The amazing actress, Cynthia Erivo, is an African American with especially prominent features, accentuated owing to the excellent applied makeup and superb acting by Erivo. Through both movies, it is obvious that she isn’t green in reality, but African American. We see the story of the witch as a case of othering. As such, especially poignant was the moment when Dorothy, believing the witch can be killed throws a bucket of water on her, an old racist trope about African Americans and bathing.

It is a fortunate accident I suppose, director John M. Chu taking perfect advantage of the fact that the witch in the original dies having had a bucket of water thrown onto her. The witch, fully adopting her role, seemingly for the good of the people of Oz, ‘dies’, but in the fiction,

merely goes into hiding. Ultimately Elphaba and Prince Fihero, turned Straw man, strike out to the desert after her sacrificial death accepting that they will forever be scapegoats should they choose to stay in Oz.

This is the naive view:

It can perhaps be with a bit of irony that one pursues the study of African American literary critiques. At once, these critiques are leveled against a system that is responsible for their own publishing. Frantz Fanon's, we might naively say, is one such example. It is perhaps uncouth to look at a book's publishers in an effort to more fully understand the semantic content of that book. Explanations of how the book came to exist are not thought to lend much support in assessing the validity of an author's claims. Unfortunately however, the temptation to do so can be quite overwhelming at times.

Perhaps there are reasons why an understanding of the processes surrounding a book's existence are an important part of the existence of that book, for instance the Western education of the author, the book's distribution, the retail outlets, libraries, and classrooms, that represent the demand for the book.

Naively, I might be led to think that without any of these artifacts of a culture, that a given book would not exist. More important however, are those specific motivations that go into the book's creation. The demands of the editor, positive reviews by reviewers, a public's insistence that such a book needs to be written. Lastly, there is a worry that only certain authors can write a given book, such that if anyone else were to write it, it would not be received by publishers, editors, or the public.

A similar critique here is Frantz Fanon's exploration of the effects of colonialism in the psychology of Africans. Of concern both for Fanon's work as well as Jackson (2020), it can be difficult to disentangle what might be considered a person's culture in isolation from the affects of colonialism. I myself am sceptical that such a project could be successful.

To read a work like Fanon's *Black Skin, White Masks*, then, for someone as unsophisticated as myself, can be quite a daunting task. All I see are continuous contradictions between the 'criticisms' of 'western imperialism' and the words themselves which to my unsophisticated ears sounds as the very words used by those 'western imperialists', at least the ones they themselves would use. In the foreword, written by Anthony Appiah, it is claimed *Masks* is confronting the psychological affects of racism.

This is an important point, given that Fanon himself is trained as a psychologist. However, Fanon begins the introduction using colonial expressions of old world notions of blackness as objects devoid of personhood. As such, he himself is doing depriving others of personhood and I am not sure why he is doing so. These expressions prove to me to be quite difficult obstacles to surmount. The 'educated elite' who will undoubtedly be well-versed in this literature by the time my own children begin to sit in their classrooms to my unsophisticated mind will have their own heads filled with the most awful views and ideas about who my children are. How are

they supposed to be able to draw from their bowels the ability to cognitively navigate around their tutors words that undoubtedly will have been shaped by these horrendous views?

The books target initially then is “black” empowerment which would involve the acquisition of knowledge. The problem with the above however, is that any correlation between knowledge and power is wrong from a Christian world view. Rather one is grounded in power if they have humility. “The fear of the Lord is the beginning of wisdom.” Collins mentions the 19th century black feminist scholar Maria Stewart, noting that she urged self-reliance and independence and that her work was suppressed along with many other black feminist scholars of the era. However, we as a society know a lot more about the importance of community and inter-personal relationships, a fact which Stewart herself draws attention to:

This is a common position in what is lauded as “African American Studies”. Often times these positions are wrapped in the language of “struggle”. While Collins notes that this “struggle” is a struggle for empowerment, it is not particularly clear who the struggle is directed at. She argues that the struggle is global and transcendent, she defines the struggle as one for “survival.” But she expands the target in this edition to include recent developments of sexuality and “sexual politics” of black womanhood.

Here, the implication is not on knowledge, knowledge without wisdom is useless and a fool’s errand, it does not lead to “empowerment”. As noted in the feminist and social epistemology literature, there are many divergent accounts of knowledge and while the discourse may focus on one account of knowledge as being central to empowerment, they are often missing other accounts of the importance of knowledge. Collins mentions the 19th century black feminist scholar Maria Stewart, noting that she urged self-reliance and independence and that her work was suppressed along with many other black feminist scholars of the era. However, we as a society know a lot more about the importance of community and inter-personal relationships, a fact which Stewart herself draws attention to:

You have souls committed to your charge. . . . It is you that must create in the minds of your little girls and boys a thirst for knowledge, the love of virtue, . . . and the cultivation of a pure heart.

Here, an important development is that Stewart draws a deep connection between knowledge and virtue.

6 The Virtue of Luck (a reading of luck and ethics from Fragility of Goodness)

What is the relationship between human virtue and environmental variables? In order for a trait to be the virtue of a human being, some would like to say that it has to represent choices, rationality, actions, beliefs. However, often times these depend on environmental variables which we do not control. Most importantly among these are the values that we hold dear to us. Whether or not we recognize the importance of close relationships for instance. However, if the luck question is accurate, even these values depend on factors that are outside of our control. Our fragility, need for loved ones, friendship, etc., can at one time depend on whether or not we've encountered sufficient hardships for instance, but even outside the experience of hardships, friendships, which are also external and an environmental variable at once hold intrinsic importance, although these are external to us. As such "human goodness is nourished, even constituted, by external happenings". [1-2]

7 Non-Scientific Deliberation

7.1 Practical Deliberation

- Not scientific
- appropriate criterion of correct choice is a person of practical wisdom (thoroughly human being)
- therefore vulnerable to ungoverned *tuche* whereas Plato thinks that a good human life, a person exercising practical wisdom is invulnerable to luck

How then are good judgments of value made?

7.1.1 The vulnerability of the Good Human Life

All human excellence requires external resources and necessary conditions.

- External objects to exercise virtues towards
- External objects to receive our virtues

The most important of these require relational virtues.

E.g.,

- Good activities of citizenship
- Political attachment
- Personal love
- Friendship

7.1.1.1 The Relational Harm of Slavery

Good character requires civic activity, good political surroundings.

A slave however, lacks:

- choice
- *philia*

A person needs to be able to make free and un-coerced choices. A slave is unable to do so since he belongs to someone else who makes choices for him. Owing to his inability to make free and unconstrained choices, a slave is unable to use their capacity for practical reason, choosing objects for their own sake. As such, they cannot share in *philia* which “is based on mutual respect for choice and character” [348].

8 Morality as Privilege

Montague Reynolds (Stetson University)

8.1 Abstract

This concerns an interesting and popular assertion, that it takes a certain amount of material wealth to be a good person. I suspect that this is a project of capitalism: buy our stuff or you will be a bad person . . .

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10 On Greek Tragedy

10.1 Three Kinds of Tragic Conflict

1. Good people being ruined because of things that just happen to them, things they do not control.
2. Good people doing bad things, things opposite of their ethical character and commitments because of things they do not control.
3. Good people doing bad things without direct physical compulsion and opposite of their ethical character and commitments though done in light of circumstances of equally bad choices.

Agammenon is waiting on the shore with his entire fleet. He intends to carry out a directive from Zeus to avenge his brother whose wife ran away with Paris, prince of Troy. However, because of an earlier transgression against Artemis, Artemis is holding back the wind, stranding his fleet. Agammenon, as the result of an omen of an eagle devouring a hare, is told that in order to appease Artemis, he must sacrifice his daughter Iphigenia.

As such, Agammenon is faced with two impossible choices, fail to carry out Zeus's command, or kill his daughter. It is important to point out that the fleet is already facing starvation being stranded on the coast. However, Agammenon's sin, is not that he chooses sacrificing his daughter, instead it is the way he sacrificed his daughter.

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11 Narrative Regrets in Truth and Fiction

God as the Best Possible Epistemic Ground of Human Dignity

Following @gold09's short paper *Narrative Thinking, Emotion, and Planning*, I consider the representation of emotional expressions of regret, *narrative regret*. I draw specific attention to the context of the representation of distinct special relationships in fiction. Important here are discourses on the fictional representation of such relationships as a special kind of human agency. I argue that a related concern are the assumptions about what is true and what is fiction in popular fiction with regard to special relationships, where what is true are expressions of relational sanctification that are grounded in a divine union of love appropriate to friendship.

11.1 Testimonial and Hermeneutic Injustice

11.1.1 Wendy Laybourn's Cost of Being Real

Wendy Laybourn (2018) draws a comparison between black authenticity and what she calls commodified realness. According to Laybourn, identity is sold to a broader public as black authenticity. This criticism is centered around the effects of what she calls *controlling images* in popular media. Of deep concern here, is that many of the members of the communities depicted by such images, consider aspects of these images to be authentic representations of themselves and the communities in which they live. Therefore, there is a public perception that such images are not in themselves harmful. If they are in some degree controlling, then they would be harmful, but there is strong disagreement regarding whether or not they are (20C History Project 2014; Collins 2006, 2009; Sartwell 1998).

Research on black authenticity identifies “oppressive othering” and “white standards of beauty”, particularly lighter skin tone, as key components of commercial success in the entertainment industry.

- Oppressive Othering (commodified black authenticity, cba)
- White Standards of Beauty (wsb)

Are rap lyrics a case of oppressive othering? By using rap lyrics, Laybourn argues that we can compare oppressive othering with white standards of beauty arguing that each are ways mass media disenfranchises individuals. However, the way she does so is by drawing attention to a positive correlation between lighter skin tone and higher Billboard chart ratings versus linking less dominant social classes with antisocial behavior.

Laybourn follows Nguyen and Anthony (2014). According to Nguyen *et al*, the research on black authenticity reveals two trends. The first is commodification when cultural productions of authenticity affect how individuals or cultural products fare in the economic market [p. 771]. The second includes constructing expectations and self-identities. Here a similar relation can be seen between rap lyrics (oppressive othering) and higher chart ratings where higher chart ratings are predicated when an artist meets particular expectations. Though at the center of this issue is that these expectations and identities justify or legitimate membership when they are fulfilled.

Therefore her suggestion seems to be that a harmful representation of blackness is sold to the public as “authentic blackness” by promoting artists with lighter skin tones. Importantly, this particular commodity then “shapes” what is accepted as authentic blackness, and what is commodified as authentic blackness. However, the implication here is that skin tone equates to one’s identity.

Therefore, here identity is constructed as authentic when the successful signification of what is accepted as “real” or “true” for cultural products, music etc, and individual’s identities (a person as an authentic artist) is socially constructed. Therefore, Nguyen *et al* suggest that the research on “black authenticity” across contexts ought to include varying ideals and expectations which affect “what it means to be black” whether in personal, public, and cultural identities [p. 779].

In addition to the “oppressive othering” of cba, “white standards” of beauty are also sold. But it isn’t clear what correlation there is between cba and wsb if any. Laybourn argues that both wsb and cba stem from attitudes which position blacks as an outgroup and whites as an in-group. I think the focus on beauty standards is distracting from what is truly important about her paper, which are those qualities that we should consider as the essential nature of a person. In other words, we should not think that the color of a person’s skin is an essential marker of who they are.

This is the naive view:

It can perhaps be with a bit of irony that one pursues the study of African American literary critiques. At once, these critiques are leveled against a system that is responsible for their own publishing. Frantz Fanon’s, we might naively say, is one such example. It is perhaps uncouth to look at a book’s publishers in an effort to more fully understand the semantic content of that book. Explanations of how the book came to exist are not thought to lend much support in assessing the validity of an author’s claims. Unfortunately however, the temptation to do so can be quite overwhelming at times.

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Naively, I might be led to think that without any of these artifacts of a culture, that a given book would not exist. More important however, are those specific motivations that go into the book's creation. The demands of the editor, positive reviews by reviewers, a public's insistence that such a book needs to be written. Lastly, there is a worry that only certain authors can write a given book, such that if anyone else were to write it, it would not be received by publishers, editors, or the public.

A similar critique here is Frantz Fanon's exploration of the effects of colonialism in the psychology of Africans. Of concern both for Fanon's work as well as Jackson (2020), it can be difficult to disentangle what might be considered a person's culture in isolation from the affects of colonialism. I myself am sceptical that such a project could be successful.

To read a work like Fanon's *Black Skin, White Masks*, then, for someone as unsophisticated as myself, can be quite a daunting task. All I see are continuous contradictions between the 'criticisms' of 'western imperialism' and the words themselves which to my unsophisticated ears sounds as the very words used by those 'western imperialists', at least the ones they themselves would use. In the foreword, written by Anthony Appiah, it is claimed *Masks* is confronting the psychological affects of racism.

This is an important point, given that Fanon himself is trained as a psychologist. However, Fanon begins the introduction using colonial expressions of old world notions of blackness as objects devoid of personhood. As such, he himself is doing depriving others of personhood and I am not sure why he is doing so. These expressions prove to me to be quite difficult obstacles to surmount. The 'educated elite' who will undoubtedly be well-versed in this literature by the time my own children begin to sit in their classrooms to my unsophisticated mind will have their own heads filled with the most awful views and ideas about who my children are. How are they supposed to be able to draw from their bowels the ability to cognitively navigate around their tutors words that undoubtedly will have been shaped by these horrendous views?

As such, cbas are dangerous when they serve as an avenue for interaction with black culture and a proxy for interpersonal interaction, as evidenced not only by Fanon, but by an entire generation of scholarship around what it means to be black. This is true because they undermine true companionship in that a person is only becoming acquainted with a false image. This image is especially harmful because it is created within a framework "that" reifies anti-blackness, but it is not only blacks that are harmed, but rather the human person. In this way, cbas have no bearing on reality, but they take on many seemingly benign forms as well. There is a public perception that such images are not in themselves harmful, for instance as evidenced with the centrality of Fanon's literature in academia, perhaps this explains the prevalence of cbas in popular culture, even among those who the images are harming most. An important consequence of this is that many of the members of the communities depicted by such images,

consider aspects of these images to be authentic representations of themselves and of the communities in which they live and of themselves. Therefore, there is strong disagreement regarding whether or not they are harmful (20C History Project 2014; Collins 2006, 2009; Sartwell 1998).

In another paper, I highlighted some concerns raised by Wendy Laybourn (2018) regarding representation and authenticity. Here, I want to draw attention to some additional similar concerns. What is important here, is that these criticisms unfairly focus too narrowly on the black experience and do not do a good enough job in recognizing that these experiences are universal. Given their universality, I argue that a best response is found in a Christian theodicy to evil as a form of suffering.

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Eleonore Stump (2010) writes on the philosophical problem of evil, arguing that what is truly of concern is not the problem of evil, but rather the problem of suffering. In order to understand the problem that evil presents, we must first understand the nature of suffering. It is in suffering that evil is the most pronounced according to Stump.

Here, an important component of suffering, is psychological dissolution where one experiences a disintegration of the will. A result of this disintegration is that a person becomes divided from themselves and is no longer able to recognize the desires of their own heart. These desires are ultimately relational. As such, the person who has become divided suffers in a state Professor Stump refers to as "willed loneliness", which is a state of psychic disintegration.

Unfortunately, I will not be able to give Professor Stump article the treatment that it deserves. However, before we can even understand what psychic disintegration is like, it is first necessary to understand why we might think union with another is a mark of spiritual health. For this, we need a theory of identity. Towards the end of this paper, I introduce such a theory. First however, I discuss a number of examples of what relational desire looks like.

11.2 Robust and Generic Expressions of Regret and Other Popular Forms of Music

The country music singer George Jones was born September 12, 1931 in Saratoga Texas. He would die at the age of 81 which is considerable considering the storied life he lived. In the podcast; *Cocaine and Rhinestones*, and later the book of the same name, Tyler Mahan Coe (2024) dismantles common tropes associated with the singer. Of special importance was Jones's popular marriage to the other country singer Tammy Wynette which Coe accuses of being an industry publicity stunt, and his marriage to Nancy Pulvado which many credit with Jones's recovery from drug and alcohol addiction.

The song *He Stopped Loving Her Today* was completed in 1979 by Bobby Braddock and Curly Putnam, writers for Nashville's Tree Publishing Company (now Sony Music Publishing) (Jones 1979). At least a year prior to its completion however, George Jones would be told about it by his producer Billy Sherrill. It would go on to be iconic of country music from the era. In it, the narrator speaks of a neighbor's dissolution of their relationship. It is never made clear what kind of relationship it is, whether a legally recognized marriage, friendship, love affair etc. However, what is made manifest throughout the song is its intensity with the narrator expressing that the day his neighbor died, is the first expression of joy he'd seen from the neighbor since his lover left.

Love songs may express regret for those moments prior to the narrator's introduction to the beloved. It is possible that when a song expresses regret for not having met someone sooner, they are thinking about how their life might have gone had they married sooner. The marriage itself is not meaningful for the individual as a stand-alone event. Rather, the marriage only has causal influence on the subsequent events of that person's life and it is the person who defines the event in such a way to make it a meaningful marker of their own identity. It is where the marriage sits in the overall context of the course of a given relationship for instance. A marriage event in the context of a short and harmful relationship has a very different meaning than one in the context of a long and loving relationship. Most importantly however, it is important in the context of the meaning that a person derives from the event.

Many popular songs are saturated in the emotion of regret. In such contexts, the narrative expresses a negative emotion in response to something a character in the narration did, or that was done to them.

In *The Grand Tour* (Jones 1974), the narrator as character expresses regret at having lost a significant other while the song *He Stopped Loving Her Today*, the narrator, giving a narrative account of someone else also expresses the regret felt by the character when their relationship dissolves. The above are emblematic country songs in that regret is commonly expressed in country music. Different songs express regret in different contexts however. *Apologize* by Timbaland is not a country song, and expresses regret in a different context. Here the narrator expresses regret for the love that he, the narrator, *had* felt.

Love songs often express regret when a relationship ends. In the song *The Grand Tour*, our attention is drawn to the daily use of items “where she used to . . .” which speak to the fact that they were once shared by people who experienced positive sentiments toward one another. Their current state however suggests that they are no longer used this way “. . . this old house will never be the same . . .”. In *The Grand Tour*, there is existing controversy over whether the end of the relationship is caused by the narrator, or someone else. In the podcast *Cocaine and Rhinestones: The history of country music*, Tyler Mahan Coe suggests that the change in the state of the lives of the individuals involved in *The Grand Tour* is the result of a tragic mishap citing these lines in the song; “There’s her rings, all her things, and her clothes are in the closet” and “as you leave you’ll see the nursery, . . . taking nothing but the baby and my heart”.

The events in *The Grand Tour* may not have been caused by the involvement from any agent. For instance, if Coe is correct, then the dissolution of the relationship depicted in *The Grand Tour* has nothing to do with any actions committed on the part of the narrator or his lost love. In *He Stopped Loving Her Today*, the regret is more definitively caused by an action when the subject whom the song speaks about is left by their significant other effectively dissolving their relationship. “He said I’ll love you ‘till I die, She told him ‘you’ll forget in time’”. Regret can be the result of either an action or an event and the regret in *The Grand Tour* is likely caused by an event, whereas in Jones’ other song, *He Stopped Loving Her Today*, it is likely caused by an action for instance if the protagonist pursued undisclosed intimate relationships with others.

While in the two previous examples *regret* is expressed upon the end of a relationship or rather its dissolution, in other examples, more positive emotions, not regret, are expressed upon the end or dissolution of the relationship rather than of the relationship’s continuance. For instance Kelly Clarkson’s *Since U Been Gone* does this: “Since you’ve been gone, I can breath for the first time . . .”. There are also different reasons for the regret whether expressed for having suffered through the ordeal of that relationship, or for its end. Sometimes the regret is expressed as a longing for various qualities the loved possessed, for instance in the *Grand Tour*, “over there, sits the chair ... and whisper ‘oh I love you’”. For these reasons, narratives can help us to feel closeness and union with the loved one even though they are fictional.

Arguably, when a subject experiences this sort of disassociation identified with suffering above, they are no longer in a position to experience regret when losing the things most dear to them. This correlates with expressions of emotion associated with love, where love has often been defined as the feeling of loving emotions provoked in one party by another. Upon the object’s absence, the subject no longer feels these emotions and experiences regret on account of this absence (Taylor 1976). The lover can also experience regret in longing for the qualities not possessed by the loved, when someone whom they loved failed to reciprocate in word or deed, or failed in some other way. For instance in Timbaland’s *Too Late to Apologize* the following line expresses this: “tell me that you need me then you go and cut me down”.

11.3 Identity Reductionism

Narrative accounts of identity attempt to use the way an individual responds to events in a person's life to identify the agent through space and time. For instance, in the agency literature, reductionists explain the metaphysical continuity of an object across space and time in terms of personal identity. Derek Parfit (1987) argues that in order to understand what sort of object a person is, we need to understand two different qualities. These include the nature of a person and their *criterion of identity*, i.e., their continued existence over time. But when we consider these qualities in contrast to persons versus non-persons, we include not only physical states of matter, but also immaterial ones such as mental states, memories, beliefs, motivations, etc. A person can be identified just if continuity between subsequent immaterial mental states and physical states are achieved.

Reductionists such as Parfit can define personal identity as the persistence of the human person over time, and say that this is reducible to the binding of psychological states with physical matter. Causalism is the most popular account that explains the origin of psychological states, an object A at time T_1 is identical to object B at time T_2 as long as we can draw a continuous line from object A at time T_1 to object B at time T_2 . The continuous line here is most often mental states such as memory, passions, character traits and dispositions. But often times it is the case that those memories we accept as definitive, have their origins in persons or events other than ourselves. There are certain dispositions I have because of persons other than myself signing various documents articulating what rights I recognize as belonging to me for instance.

While Parfit's account does show how persons are not mere matter, he and other causalists state that an action performed by an agent, is an event caused by the mental state of that agent (Altshuler 2021). The difficulty arises in understanding how mental states are related to prior events. While a mental state may be the source of some event, another event may be the source of another mental state. Regardless of the relationship between mental states and the material universe, it is not clear where the causal chain originates.

Korsgaard (1989) has argued that on Parfit (1987)'s account of identity, a person is primarily a *locus of experience* (Korsgaard 1989, 103). This means that the way to identify an object as existing through space and time as it correlates with a person, is by identifying a set of experiences between objects across space and time that are connected through a set of events or some other connecting factor. These events are psychological states and 'spatiotemporally continuous living bod[ies]' (Korsgaard 1989, 104). In this way I might define myself as *an American* and defend such values as independence and freedom. It is plausible then to draw a line from events in 1776, America's founding, to my present day. Therefore I associate various values I hold with events that transpired in 1776 and as such, the psychological states I currently have, have their own origins centuries before. In other words, because a person's psychological states have prior causes, the states themselves are merely some form of event and experience.

Narrative accounts then are responses to impersonal accounts. According to narrative accounts, how we frame events such as these, is what makes the event meaningful for a given individual (Schechtman 1996, 96). Without narratives, the agency and the identity of the subject is lost among a causal chain of events. This has been called ‘constitution’. In terms of the constitution model of identity, without the binding effect of narrative, the subject of a given event is victim to a disparate causal chain of cause and effect. Our identity then would merely be an impersonal metaphysical continuation of matter (Korsgaard 1996).

Altshuler identifies a problem with the above account, namely that it does not account for those events that are not selected by the agent. He argues that such events do have a causal effects on what ultimately constitutes one’s identity. Following Peter Goldberg (2009), Altshuler instead identifies narrative with an agent’s *ability* to reconfigure their motivational and psychological past with respect to their own reactions to these events. In other words, Altshuler too, defends a self-constitution model of agency and identity, but one on which a person’s responses to his or her past, shape her future identity.

At the center of the difference between popular narratives like those found in popular songs and narrative identity accounts is that popular narratives are merely ones we are prompted to imagine (Gilmore 2020, 132). But the source of narrative identities is not clear. The question then is what connection do those narratives have to those that we are prompted to imagine. John Gilmore (2020) suggests that the relationship is weak and dependent on the function of the imagination for engaging with the work.

One way narrative identity may relate to popular narratives, is if a response is required by the artist that maps onto what an audience perceives as normative. However, Gilmore (2020) rejects this arguing that different popular narratives have different responses. Further, these responses are not justified by normative expressions of emotion, where the emotion elicited by the context is one we would expect outside the popular narrative [p. 132]. Rather, Gilmore defends an intentionalist stance of normative discontinuity. According to this stance, an author’s intentions constrain and justify the emotional response of their audiences. Accordingly, laughter which would otherwise be inappropriate would be an apt response to some fiction. It is not clear whether this view can justify one’s identification with a racist trope of themselves however.

Patricia Hill Collins and Wendy Laybourn on the other hand suggest a strong relationship (Collins 2006, 2009; Laybourn 2018). The narratives in popular media are controlling images designed to justify racist and sexist attitudes.

Controlling images “are designed to make racism, sexism, poverty, and other forms of social injustice appear to be natural, normal, and inevitable parts of everyday life” (Collins 2009, 77).

It is important to point out here that I am not asking about purpose or the design of such prompted imaginings. Rather that focusing on Laybourn’s context of ‘authenticity’ and ‘realness’ highlights a popular implicit assumption regarding what is true and what is fiction in popular media. Peter Goldberg (2009) highlights our emotions as a form of reflection, especially

that of regret. Sometimes as agents, the expressions of regret enables one to better exercise their own agency. We can imagine someone being cheated through the purchase of a used car. Looking towards the future, that individual would exercise more caution as a consequence upon reflection of their mistake. In these moments, the ability to tell a story becomes important as we are enabled by the narrative to recognize the appropriate objects of our emotions in the story. Reflecting on the failed used car purchase, the subject experiences regret. This subsequent experience pushes them to exercise more caution in the future. Similarly, we can compare this to another example. Here, regret is either appropriate to aspects of the story which bear no direct relation on the narrator, or ones that do. Being able to recognize and reflect on emotions enables one to express their agency going forward. What regret is afforded to the subject when reflecting on decisions made by themselves?

In this context, narrative is substantial in our lives as it provides ways of thinking about how our lives may have gone differently, or may go differently and why; our plans for the future and how things might turn out.¹ Thinking in this way leads to regret if we are disappointed in a particular choice we have made. Our feelings of regret can cause us to behave differently in the future. Questions about narrative thinking then just are questions about moral agency.

Importantly, the possible prospect of being able to imagine today what a morally good life will look like for us tomorrow, is a question about how what we believe about ourselves today, including what desires we have, influence our ability to pursue these ways of being. These in turn determine our regrets. Imagining what kind of person our spouse will be can perhaps open up some romantic possibilities while closing others. Imagining where we will buy our first home may restrict our career choices, just like imagining how many children we will have may affect where we want to live. But more importantly, having various beliefs about ourselves under gird all these other possibilities.

More importantly, we can develop a sense of agency when we imagine ways in which our friendships, family ties, and other important relationships will go. These are preceded by beliefs in us about ways they *could* go. We can imagine the type of person we are to others and take needed steps for becoming that person, if we believe it is possible. As such, the person we will be and how we will relate to others is the goal that is formed by a narrative. Consider one particular narrative, we imagine ourselves as thoughtful, kind, considerate, loving, or compassionate. Imagining ourselves this way becomes the motivation we need to read up on the latest parenting methods. We might imagine ourselves being invited to witness the birth of a friend's first child and scour the internet for advice on how to be a better gift giver.

While the argument that the way we imagine our lives going can have a positive causal effect on the kind of person we become, one may argue that this view is too optimistic. To what extent do the experiences we have shape the person we become? For instance, Eric J. Miller (2020) argues that victimhood imposes normative standards that ground the moral status of

¹For contrast, see Michael Bratman (2000) argues that as agents, we are purposeful and reflective about our motivations, and capable of organizing our activity over and in-line with our purposes and motivations as we reflect on them. One method of reflection involves the expressions of various emotions upon the occurrence of some event.

the victim. What he means is that social roles, such as victim, determine the values we are expected to live by.

As a victim, there are various normative standards imposed on us that undermine our ability to imagine other parenting styles and values, such as those relating to how we protect and nourish our children. Libertarian values may be those we are less apt to promote in our homes. One reason is that when victims as parents, or the parents of victims, instruct a child, they must instruct them to act in self-subordinating ways “when confronted by the police” [221] rather than in ways that assert their autonomy.

Consider the following example narratives:

- Ty Dolla’s *by Yourself*: “Stacked your bread and bought your own Mercedes (Vroom, vroom). You your own boss, do it your way (Way)

The song’s protagonist is faced with a given environment that forces her to exert her independence rather than her social bonds. As such, her lack of regret is a normative standard imposed on her. We can contrast this situation with the possibility that while material goods may or may not be a necessary condition for well-being, they are certainly not a sufficient one as expressed in other popular songs. The protagonist in the song *Rich and Sad* by Post Malone, looks back over other events, motives, and desires that resulted in the dissolution of his relationship and he feels sadness, as an expression of regret:

- “All this stuntin’ couldn’t satisfy my soul (–oul), Got a hundred big places, but I’m still alone (–one)”.

First, each of the above narratives are constrained by beliefs the narrator may have about themselves. In the first, the narrator, believing they have no other choice but to cut themselves off from anyone who is unable to contribute financially. But it does lead to another criticism, the agency of the artist versus that of the audience. Some music criticisms will often point out that musical taste assumes a sense of moral autonomy not available to some. If an artist is accustomed to abject poverty, then that person might be seen as vulnerable to market forces, creating art that is in high demand for the purposes of financial gain (Laybourn 2018), or only capable of representing their immediate physical environment (Richardson and Scott 2002). Regret within narratives are an example of such narrative agency. But if Eric Miller is correct, then some populations just do not possess agency in the requisite sense. But this view would thoroughly undermine decades of social justice movements in law and elsewhere.

The common responses to such criticisms come in two forms. They typically make some causal claim about the effects of environment on both artistic performance (Richardson and Scott 2002), and audience music selection criteria, for instance, that artists are merely defining their personal experiences (Shusterman 2007, 419). This responses highlight unequal wealth opportunities imposing normative standards on their victims. The second kind of response makes a cultural claim deriving from supposed traditional practices in pre-colonial Africa (Abrahams 2006).

Importantly here, the responses that are grounded in assertions about the culture of pre-colonial Africa are not necessarily a response to the empirical claims about the representations of anti-social behavior in rap and hip-hop music, but rather to the metaphorical use of language exhibited by pre-colonial African tribal practices. What are commonly noted as anti-social themes in rap and hip-hop then are downplayed as word-play underlying a cultural or political critique or something else entirely. Namely the references to violence and misogyny are allegorical, not literal (Smitherman 1997; Gates 1989).

Magnus and Malone (2023) give such an account by highlighting the criminal prosecutions that cite song lyrics as testimonial confessions. Malone argues that being too generous in treating artistic assertions as truth in songs, commits the harm of art-interpretive injustice. She argues that the listener, in this case the prosecution, extends the wrong degree of credibility to the artist. Instead of interpreting the song lyrics as art, the listener interprets the lyrics as testimony.

Importantly, a component of Malone's argument is that prosecutions do not treat other genres of music based on the content of their art. However, there is another and more important issue at concern here. This worry is found in the dual character account of art Malone has previously defended. There, Malone argues that *authentic* country music is a dual character art-form that embodies "the core value commitments of the genre" (Malone 2023, 1). According to this view, country music, like punk rock and hip-hop (Liao, Meskin, and Knobe 2020) constitute core value commitments. As such, following the dual character account of art, it is not clear what level of credibility we should assign to the song lyrics in criminal prosecutions.

Consider the following dialogue used by Liao, Meskin, and Knobe (2020), 7-8:

11.3.0.1 The Scientist

Alfie: She is not a scientist. I know many people think she is a scientist, but when you think about what scientists really are, you will realize that she is not a scientist at all.

Betty: Of course she is a scientist. She is skilled at running experiments and publishing in scientific journals.

Alfie: That is not what I meant! What I meant is that she does not possess a genuine willingness to revise her beliefs in light of empirical evidence.

11.3.0.2 The Christian

Alfie: She is not a Christian. I know many people think she is a Christian, but when you think about what it really means to be a Christian, you will realize that she is not a Christian at all.

Betty: Of course she is a Christian. She goes to church every week and believes that Jesus is the son of God.

Alfie: That is not what I meant! What I meant is that she does not show genuine compassion.

Malone follows Liao, Meskin, and Knobe (2020) who argue that we can “pick out the concepts” for which people make various judgments as those above, by distinguishing them from the kinds of judgments “from concepts for which people would not make such judgments” (Liao, Meskin, and Knobe 2020, 6). Here, many things will both satisfy and at the same time fail to satisfy the criteria that allows one to make identity judgments. I argue that here, as a character attribution, these concepts enable one to judge whether someone *truly* belongs to a given category.

What is important among these responses however, is that they too undermine attributions of personal identity and human agency and go against the dual character concept of art. A question they force us to ask, is what songs belong in a given category? Separately, some have held that we can determine the values an artist holds, by carefully listening to the song lyrics they write. Although this fact would suggest that an artist’s lyrics might qualify as a personal narrative defining an artist’s identity and agency, it is not clear whether such narratives would qualify on this account of narrative agency.

Altshuler’s account could give more credence to music lyrics as an example narrative in the psychological sense, it is not clear how this may be the case. According to some accounts, an artist’s written lyrics and musical arrangement merely express plausible values someone might hold (Malone 2023), while others articulate them as more definitive (Meissner and Huebner 2022), still others argue that art is functional (Gilmore 2020), thereby leaving open the possibility they could count as narrative in the functional sense, but do not do so necessarily.

For instance, Whyte (2018), Meissner and Huebner (2022) have argued that *settler colonial imaginaries* define what they call *settler* ecologies. These are narratives that replace existing narratives. They are pro-social concepts that are central for members of a given community and include beliefs that are central to a group’s flourishing. They can include songs that invoke tropes of indigenous identities. Tim McGraw’s song *Indian Outlaw* is an example of this sort of practice. In the song he claims to be half Cherokee and half Choctaw. But it is ambiguous whether he is referring to the character, or if the song is loosely biographical. Either way, it offers a portrait about what it means to be indigenous American. Importantly, the song is not aiming at the truth of what it means to be indigenous American. As such, Meissner and Huebner (2022) would argue that it *fortifies ignorance* of the people and the land that they inhabit. Most importantly, it undermines relational networks between the people that would sustain their *co-flourishing*.

It may be that rap and hip-hop are not good example narratives. But they show promise. Consider the question above, is some material good a necessary and sufficient condition for well-being as expressed in some popular songs? As narratives, the two examples above would

better explain why some event happened. Why the protagonist in *by yourself* severed their relationship with their significant other, and why the protagonist in *Rich and Sad* is rich and sad.

Here, we primarily contrast [money] as the material object expressing that it:

- “could satisfy my soul”

And contrasting this with [money] as the material object expressing that it:

- “could not satisfy my soul”.

One way that narratives are thought to explain agency then, is by synchronizing incongruous events, states, and motives. As such, a narrative can say yes, money is either a necessary and sufficient condition for well-being for some agent or not. As such, the expressions of regret offers a plausible way to recognize the core of one’s agency.

Recognizing the form of some plausible narratives may help to understand how to recognize a narrative if we say it. The various incidents and events have made it difficult for the agent to recognize value in non-material objects. We can, and often do, ask a meta-ethical question about what kinds of objects are truly of moral value and why. The narrative provides us with a plausible account of the why. For instance, we can ask to what extent the quest for consumer goods ought to outweigh other pursuits such as time with one’s children or calling one’s mother on Sunday. What is probably missing from the above is the understanding that there is a difference between only some material possession being necessary for well-being, versus some non-material possession being necessary for well-being.

But exactly how are material and non-material objects expressed over and against one another? It may be the case that volunteering at an orphanage is of moral value and it can be expressed in song in at least two ways. Lyrically, “I wish I had volunteered at the orphanage yesterday”. Or lyrically that expresses a negative outcome for not having volunteered at the orphanage yesterday. In constructing lyrics of the second form, the author chooses words that either have been historically encoded with the sentiment she is hoping to ascribe to a state of affairs, or is potentially encoded with that sentiment in such a way that the desired emotion is potentially ascribed to that state of affairs. However, if I neglect my children in volunteering at an orphanage, then *my* volunteering is of reduced moral value and we could imagine a lyrics saying “I wish I had spent time with my children instead of volunteering at the orphanage yesterday”, or that says “I spent so many hours at the orphanage that I do not know who my own children are anymore”; or “I spent hours at the orphanage, I do not know who my own children are anymore”.

We can also express a normative question about what behaviors are appropriate, when we should be kind, or whether a given action is more kind than another using similar methods. But there are additional interesting questions. As inferred above, we ask about the context in which a given ethical question is of moral value, and we can express it as a value by inviting the audience to reflect on such expressions by coercing their emotions accordingly. Volunteering my

time at an orphanage is of moral value, and so I would use music or poetry to evoke emotions in the audience that correspond with this value. Considering the context is a way to assess the rationality of a given question, emotional expression in art is a way to make sense of that question. Making sense of the question helps us to anticipate the answer in at least two ways, what does the artist suggest is valuable, we would then look at the emotional expressions in her art, and what is the agent potentially capable of valuing.

For instance, assuming that Jill is the last sentient creature on a far away planet, it may not make sense to ask what Jill's ethical obligations are to those around her. But contexts regarding ethical questions are important. There are two important such contexts here; socio-economic or cultural environments, and psychological or social ones. Given questions about morality, our concerns are largely about how we should behave toward others. For many years, this was answered by referencing cultural and socio-economic conditions. More controversially, it has also been answered by referencing psychological or social conditions. But this is not the same as asking whether a given question about ethical obligation makes sense or not. It would not make sense to say a person with a medical condition that precludes the experience of empathy, has an ethical obligation to experience the emotions that align with empathy. There is a way in which our questions about moral behavior should make sense. This is in the context of our behavior toward others. Most humans, will generally live in contexts wherein our behavior to others should have a kind of rationality about them, in valuing our relationships with others.

The social version of this question is more opaque. It is a question about our social environments and to what extent our social environments can provide us with the resources necessary to fulfill our moral obligations. Once again, there are two categories of question here. For instance, consider our choices as to what kind of careers would make fulfilling our moral obligations possible. If we recognize a moral obligation to give vast amounts of wealth to charity, then we could pursue a set of social connections (work hard in high school and get into a good university) that would make our ability to fulfill this obligation more likely. The other category of question is even more difficult however. It begins as a question about ourselves and the sources of our beliefs as to what is possible, and what is not. We would start with a question about what is true about ourselves. Related to this is a question about what extent do those around us contribute to our beliefs about what is true about ourselves and what is obligatory in regard to our behavior. If we consider that we have a moral obligation to support national health, then there are some political parties we might campaign on behalf of and others we would not. Here I suggest then that how we should understand such questions is in the form of a narrative.

12 Comments on Reconstructions of Ballet Classics

Montaque Reynolds (Stetson University)

- How should the contemporary dance community assess the authenticity of classical ballet reconstructions? Two important possibilities include the work's musical notations, and the work's text or story (Van Camp unpublished draft, 1). The distinction here seems to be between a work's syntax, akin to its grammatical structure, and its semantics, or meaning.
- On the one hand, the authenticity of a musical work is determined by its compliance with a musical score (Kania 2024). In ballet, we have the musical score and so it is plausible that we determine the work's authenticity through a positive assessment of its compliance with a musical score and dance score, but for reconstructions of nineteenth-century works, we do not have the dance notations. Yet despite the lack of a work's dance score, we still consider the work authentic.
- Therefore it is not clear whether the authenticity of a ballet performance also relies solely on compliance with its musical score. Traditionally this has meant that the choreography is amenable to change without affecting our understanding of the authenticity of the performance.
- Professor Julie Van Camp then asks what factors in 19th century ballet reconstructions and reenactments help us to determine whether a given dance is authentic, accurate, or neither.
- One possibility is requiring the same sets of standards that would be employed when considering a historical item for display in a museum.
- One helpful heuristic of the contrast between reenactment and reconstruction then, is the focus on demonstrating how a dance might be redone versus a phenomenological way of understanding "what it was *like to do it*" (Franko 2017, 1). One helpful label of this work then would be to focus on the authenticity of a given performance either as being compliant with a score, or compliance with the original meaning of the work.

- Using the definition offered by Mark Franko (2017) in his introduction to the Oxford handbook of dance and reenactment, reconstructions are preservations of past accomplishments while it is not yet clear whether reenactments aim to reimagine those past performances instead, or whether these have some additional aim.
- On this later point, it would appear that there are many important reasons for re-imagining a ballet performance.
- For one, if we do not have an authentic historical item from a particular time period to include in a museum collection from that time period, it may make sense to use the nearest counterpart.
- Analogously, considering the 19th century ballet performances *Swan Lake*, *Giselle* and *The Sleeping Beauty*, these exist though we do not have relevant dance notations of their original performances.
- Therefore it would be an important project to determine what the nearest counterpart might be since there are at least two different ways to understand the term “nearest counterpart”. One important direction of consideration here, is that an important part of the essence of a performance, apart from its compliance with either a music or dance score would be the emotional essence of a given performance.

Lukacs (1977) argues that a work’s emotional essence is produced by social factors.

- But these do not seem to be factors that can be displayed in a museum in the traditional sense.
- Perhaps the closest terms we have for this distinction in the reenactment and reconstruction literature, is what Andrew Kania (2024) attributes to Julian Dodd (2020); ‘compliance’ authenticity versus ‘*interpretive*’ authenticity.
- First, Professor Van Camp carefully and expertly draws out the complications for understanding why this is a hard problem.
- In three prominent examples of the reconstructions of the 19th century pieces, *Swan Lake*, *Giselle*, and *Sleeping Beauty*, if we focus on audience reactions to these pieces, then the ‘reconstructions’ do not appear to have been as appealing as their 19th century reenactment counterparts since audience favor typically follows works that reimagine classics.
- This later position is explored with more detail in a review written by Professor Van Camp explaining the loose requirements for authenticity in ballet reenactments versus those of reconstructions, usually focus on a shift of social values.
- Tamara Rojo as the artistic director for the San Francisco Ballet delicately introduces variations in her version of *Raymonda* by “expunging Middle Eastern stereotypes” and exploring new forms of agency by introducing a female heroine rather than a male hero.

- This shows the tolerance ballet has for variation without loss of ontological identity.
- But this may also just mean that a work’s ontological identity is grounded somewhere else.
- Professor Van Camp defends these loose standards as authentically derivative since often times our own standards are amenable to change in other areas, such as values which we know have strong emotive force.
- A central question here then could be the shifting plasticity of standards and how these diverge between reconstructions and reenactments.
- This is especially important if we consider whether there is a more ultimate and underlying truth at which multiple performances of a work may attempt to reveal.
- At the Paris 1913 premier of *Le Sacre du Printemps* staged by Vaslav Nijinsky, it is said that the audience rioted owing to the near primal movements of the performers.
- In 2009, the resident choreographer for the Boston Ballet premiered a version of *Le Sacre du Printemps* that diverged from Nijinsky’s “uncontrolled and raw movements” with the introduction of “clean shapes, intricate isolations, and dynamic partner work”.
 - Elo defends his interpretation arguing that highlighting the performances universal value of “community, identity, and social systems” did not require the “sacrifice for the common good” that it required when Nijinsky staged the work in 1913.
- This is important considering the role the performance played in moving the theater into the modern era of ballet.
- But this also leads to an additional question, how audiences think of these 19th century reconstructions as authentic and historically accurate and why and what this means for our accepted notions of authenticity and accuracy.
- Perhaps it is not necessary here to make any comment on what is considered an audience.
- Some audiences desire to ‘view the past accomplishments of dance’ and others are more interested in imagining what a historical performance would look like when adding the benefit of ‘improved diet, health, and training regimes’ of the modern period.

As noted by Julian Dodd (2020) in his *Being True to Works of Music*, it is possible that the distinction here then, is one between ‘compliance’ authenticity and ‘interpretive’ authenticity.

- For instance, it is not clear whether Professor Van Camp follows Andrew Kania (2024) in equating ‘authenticity’ with ‘genuineness’ so that an ‘authentic’ performance is a mere ‘genuine’ interpretation of a score, and more importantly what this has to do with the compliance and interpretation distinction.
- However, one plausible direction in which this discussion could move, is through a focus on interpretive authenticity.

- The biggest complication here is that taking the understanding of producing a ‘genuine’ work means producing an ‘authorized’ score for that work.
- But this is not all that determines the authenticity of a work.
- There are many considerations that go into producing an ‘authorized’ score.

Lukacs (1977) would argue that these considerations include the underlying values the score seeks to express.

- Professor Van Camp considers *Swan Lake*, *The Sleeping Beauty*, and *Giselle* since there are instances of these works that were created without a choreographic notational system.
- The inclusion of the notational system in order to be authorized then, needs to account of fidelity to some expressed value.
- Therefore, this fact will have us question the conditions for understanding a work rely solely on the *musical* notation ascribed to a ballet performance and not specific features of the dance itself.
- Therefore there are at least two different standards for a work’s authenticity.
- So while it is not clear what the standards are for a work being authentic, * Professor Van Camp may accept the ballet reconstruction as authentic simply if it complies with the musical score.
- But using the 1913 performance of *Le Sacre du Printemps* in Paris staged by Nijinsky and the 2009 version staged by Elo, another important question emerges.
- Here, maybe there are underlying values which a work intends to portray and we can either expect riots when a performance fails to express them adequately, or acclaim when they succeed.
- With ballet, which can contain both musical and choreographic scores, it would seem that there are additional factors one may consider when attempting to determine authenticity besides fidelity to a performances musical, or dance score.
- So even if we only consider the musical score for a historic ballet performance, there are still multiple types of authenticity we can rely on and what the scores these are is not clear.

13 Puzzles and Mysteries

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14 Scope, Outline

1. Use open world/sand box/MMO video games to create unique thought experiments through video game play.
2. Use these thought experiments to motivate moral reasoning and moral decision making.
3. Read and analyze classical literature to understand the use of literature and multi-media in moral development.
4. Conceptually develop games based on scenes in the literature we read.

I recently defended a dissertation in philosophy. One of the questions that philosophers discuss is the way in which personal identity, who we understand ourselves to be, is socially and culturally constructed. Some more well known examples include music, e.g., folk songs, cultural dances, etc. However, more recently discussions about video games have begun to become prevalent in this area, for instance consider the unjust depiction of urban community members in Grand Theft Auto.

Art can be thought of as a form of counterfactual argument, a way to negotiate a common practical identity.¹ One form of the representational arts, e.g., music (feelings), stage performances, movies, etc.

Consider: moral reasons why an emotion is unmerited (Gilmore 2020, 130)

- Laughing at the victim of bullying
1. Phillip L. Hammack “Narrative and the Cultural Psychology of Identity”, *process* of identity development represents the link between self and society” (Hammack 2008, 224)
 2. Marya Schechtman “Personhood and Personal Identity”, self-knowledge: ‘Is this really what I believe?’; ‘Is this really what I desire?’; ‘Is this really what I intend?’; “The resources involved in answering these questions would be resources that allowed a person to assign particular psychological states to herself . . .” (Schechtman 1990, 89)
 3. Peter Goldie, “Narrative Thinking, Emotion, and Planning”, ties feelings of regret to what he calls ‘narrative thinking’, but might be better understood as narrative identity or ‘narrative agency’.

Now, in narrative thinking, when we look back with regrets on what we did and said, and we look forward in making self-governing policies in the light of those regrets, we *necessarily* see ourselves as agents persisting over time. More expanded type

¹Malone (2023), 14

of representation wherein the player does not merely need to follow the reasoning of the creator of the artwork, but can exercise even more human agency perhaps exemplifying her own character even more.

The open-world, MMO, sandbox nature of the developing video game, space sim Star Citizen is a great example of this. Whereas games like the GTA series make it obvious and explicit that success in the game can only be had by exercising what are typically called vices, Star Citizen lets the player define success and methods of success. What Robson and Meskin (2016) may call “interactive fictions”.

Here, the game’s developer relinquishes a modicum of agency so that the player can develop her own. Not only execution element, but uniquely agential as well.

In these, the player can follow one of the many narratives together, or combine several together into their own unique narrative experience. Or they could choose to ignore any of the narratives and either explore, grief others which is a kind of wholly novel narrative experience, or create their own narratives either in a piece-meal fashion (allow their choices to define the narrative arc), or design and build a narrative.

14.1 Project Description

1. Year 1: Open world games and custom moral thought experiments
2. Year 2: Group readings of literary works and writing projects aimed at developing video games
3. Year 3: Learning how to use a game engine and publish a game
4. Year 4: Perfecting the game and learning how to make a portfolio
5. Post high school: Mentor current students
6. Post high school: Mentor current high school students and 1st year university students

It will be a four year after school program. Year one will begin by inviting them to play open world games, games that do not prescribe any sort of game play but allows the player to choose their own in-game objectives.

The next stage (year 2) will involve group readings of literary works that invite the reader to imagine themselves as a member of some given culture. In the second semester the students will develop a project wherein they will come up with a plan for creating their own work of art that invites the audience to imagine themselves as a member of a given culture this will be a writing project.

In year 3, the students will spend the first semester learning how to use a game engine and the second semester they will learn how to publish their game.

Year 4, the students will perfect their game, and learn how to make a portfolio.

Ultimately, I would like the students to come back after high school to mentor current students, whether they are working or during breaks from university.

14.2 Budget

14.2.1 Curriculum Development

- Design Curriculum for 1 course per semester for beginning
 - Develop literature-based game concepts (e.g., adapting Nicomachean Ethics scenes).
 - Hire instructional designers, game developers, and literature scholars. (Not confident about this direction)
- Build Learning Management System (LMS) for the course
 - This may be done by using grok (already in progress)
 - However, if needed to right away, can temporarily use open source LMS, e.g., Frappe (SLU?)
 - * Free, but requires a hosting plan
 - * Best option is Oracle Cloud Free Tier
 - * For duration of \$300 credit
 - * \$10-\$20/month afterwards
 - * Second best is to self-host on linux machine

14.2.2 Pilot the Program

- Pilot the program with 10 students
 - YMCA, Schools, BWorks alumni, libraries
 - Star Citizen Licenses, \$450 per semester x 4
 - Set up guest speakers, Graduate students, interested professors
 - SLU: use esports lab. Offer space to faculty for their students.

14.2.3 Evaluation and Research

- Assess moral reasoning outcomes, tests, papers, etc. Plus qualitative feedback, interviews, etc.
- Publish results in peer-reviewed journals

14.2.4 Seattle Expansion and Scaling (2–3 years): \$200,000–\$600,000

- Adapt curriculum for Seattle schools and esports organizations (e.g., Seattle Surge).
- Partner with tech-driven institutions (e.g., University of Washington).
- Market to game studios (e.g., Bungie).

15 Presence in Pedagogy: At the Heart of Learning Philosophy

The perceptual illusion of nonmediation:

- Communication, psychology is an attempt to understand how we understand and interpret information in nonmediated settings, store and retrieve information, memories, make decisions. (3)
- 1. Presence as social richness: “presence is the extent to which a medium is perceived as sociable, warm, sensitive, personal, or intimate when it is used to interact with other people. (Short, Williams, and Christie, 1976)” , (5).
- 2. Presence as realism: “presence is the degree to which a medium can produce seemingly accurate representations of objects, events, and people—representations that look, sound, and/or feel like the ‘real’ thing” (6).
- 3. Presence as transportation: “user is transported to another place”.
- 4. Presence as immersion: “the degree to which the virtual environment submerges the perceptual system of the user” (Biocca & Delaney, 1995, p. 57).
- 5. Presence as social actor within medium: user’s responses “to social cues presented by persons they encounter within a medium even though it is illogical and even inappropriate to do so”. [See Lombard, 1995 and Lemish, 1982]
- 6. Presence as medium as social actor: “social responses of media users to cues provided by the medium itself [13].

But what is the distinction of presence in mediated and nonmediated environments? Arguably, if the illusion is not an illusion, but fact about the environment, then we would say that the person is present.

An “illusion of nonmediation” occurs when a person fails to perceive or acknowledge the existence of a medium in his/her communication environment and responds as he/she would if the medium were not there. [13]

Nonmediated: experienced without human-made technology

Nonmediated presence, experience w/o human-made tech Mediated presence, experience *as though* w/o human-made tech

16 Simulating Philosophy and other Lab Experiments

16.1 Simulating Philosophy by Marcus Schulzke

- Schulzke proposes studying video games as executable narrative thought experiments.

Thought experiments in philosophy refer to hypothetical scenarios that are used to challenge or substantiate a theory.

James (1993): narratives that lead readers or listeners through a sequence of events that reflect how one would experience the real world. In this way, they are abstract models of more complex issues. They eliminate or simplify extraneous information in order to focus on the elements of an event that raise a theoretical challenge.

- Used to challenge a theory by identifying a difficult case a theory cannot answer.
- Can model situations that may be untestable using empirical methods.
- Less dangerous than real world experiments.
 - For instance, consider experiments about euthanasia or abortion.
 - Duties to one another (One hour one life)
 - Cooperative activity (Eve Online, Star Citizen)

16.2 What is Going On?

16.2.1 Thought Experiment One

Nicholas Rescher (1991):

- Thought experiments can be used to assess theoretical and empirical research questions.

A ‘thought experiment’ is an attempt to draw instruction from a process of hypothetical reasoning that proceeds by eliciting the consequences of an hypothesis which, for aught that one actually knows to the contrary, may well be false. It consists in reasoning from a supposition that is not accepted as true—perhaps is

even known to be false—but is assumed provisionally in the interests of making a point or resolving a conclusion.

- It is to be shown that P is the case (where it has not yet been established whether P or not $\neg P$).
- Assume—as “thought experiment”—that P is the case (which is not inherently implausible).
- Explain Q on the basis of this assumption, where Q is something patently true which we could not readily explain otherwise.
- Hence maintain that P .

16.2.2 Thought Experiment Two

John Norton (1991):

Thought experiments are arguments which:

1. Posit hypothetical or counterfactual states of affairs, and
 2. Invoke particulars irrelevant to the generality of the conclusion.
- *hypothetical or counterfactual* opposite of actual.
 - *irrelevant particulars* irrelevant to the conclusion.

Thus, in one version of the thought experiment in which Einstein sought to demonstrate that the effects of acceleration mimic those of gravitation, he asked us to imagine a physicist-observer who has been drugged and reawakens closed up inside a box (Einstein, 1912, pp. 1254-55). . . . Without particulars such as these, however, thought experiments would not have their experimental appearance.

Good thought experiments are good arguments. Either:

1. The particular-free conclusion follows deductively from the premisses. Thought experiments of this type are typically *reductio* arguments.
2. The conclusion is freed of the particulars by an inductive step. This step might involve the assertion that the case involving the particulars is ‘typical’ or that the particulars are ‘inessential,’ so that the result derived holds in other cases as well.

Part II

Drafts & Notes

17 Notes

There are several ways in which some art objects may represent more complex realities. One may think that the purpose of a painting is to reflect the experiences one had during a war, or peace time event. Such a painting may express the given facts of the case, for instance an artist could paint the signing of the Magna Carta.

If the painting were painted by an artist who was alive to witness the signing of the Magna Carta, then the artist would merely be representing contemporary reality. If the artist were not alive at the time, then we could argue that the artist is representing historical reality. The artist is relying on trusted and well known sources would be different from the artist imagining an event in which not many direct sources exist. But an artist can represent a projection of reality as well when the reality they want to convey is obscure, not well known, highly contested or hypothetical.

Moral (2021) argues that art's purpose in the middle ages is to represent reality. It is one thing to accurately and factually represent a tree, however, Pinero is talking about more complex reality, especially moral reality. One example of medieval representations of moral reality include the Persian Manticore. The manticore as depicted in medieval art is said to represent evil.

According to this definition of medieval art, art implies metaphysical aspirations and normative elements (Also see De Bruyne 1959). Its commitment to reality is undeniable, yet the reality which it attempts to represent is so complex and vast that the limits between what is and what is not, between what we believe and what we know, between what we are and what we wish to be, are often blurred (cron41?).

Here, the artist can represent facts as they believe them to be, or as they wish them to be. It is this latter motivation that Pinero suggests motivated medieval artwork representing the manticore. There is a difference here then between modern and medieval artistic function. This in itself is uninteresting. However, what may be more interesting to the reader, is the further claim that this difference can be applied in response to the contemporary account of epistemic injustice.

17.0.1 Wendy Laybourn's Cost of Being Real

Wendy Laybourn (2018) draws a comparison between black authenticity and what she calls commodified realness. According to Laybourn, identity is sold to a broader public as black

authenticity. This criticism is centered around the effects of what she calls *controlling images* in popular media. Of deep concern here, is that many of the members of the communities depicted by such images, consider aspects of these images to be authentic representations of themselves and the communities in which they live. Therefore, there is a public perception that such images are not in themselves harmful. If they are in some degree controlling, then they would be harmful, but there is strong disagreement regarding whether or not they are (20C History Project 2014; Collins 2006, 2009; Sartwell 1998).

18 Currie's Fiction

Why do we think that fairy tales are fiction but news stories are not? Is fake news the same thing as a fairy tale? During the pandemic, fake news became a widely discussed talking point. A less widely discussed talking point however was why don't we just call it fiction? A derivative of this question is how fiction is made possible. Meaning, what are the creative differences between fake news, news news and fairy tales? To answer this question, Gregory Currie (1990) suggests three possible answers.

According to the front page news, the terrorist leader Amelia Boyd was killed by the Headhunters Gang. First are the characteristics that distinguish fiction from non-fiction. This question is a close investigation of the entities that are in fiction and make them possible. For instance, the psychological and linguistic resources that producers and consumers of fiction must have access to.

First, consider that fiction uses language. But there is no universal linguistic feature shared by all fictional works and there is no available proof/s confirming what is a fiction. We usually think that reading a work is an act of reading words and sentences that make it up.² However, consider a mime? Or silent films? These are works that do not use language in the traditional sense, yet we consider them fictional. Therefore, what makes something a fiction cannot necessarily be a linguistic feature. Therefore what makes something a fiction is neither a necessary nor sufficient condition for being fictional. Finally then, something can be a fiction because of its verbal structure, but what makes it a fiction does not lie in the text itself.

18.1 Semantic Properties

Currie concludes that fictionality is a relational property, it is something possessed in virtue of the text's relations to other things. Therefore while it is possible that fictionality is a linguistic matter, what makes it a fiction lies in some other property. (a method of communication or other communicative practice)

On this account, fictional properties, like non-fictional ones, have the semantic properties of truth value and reference. What this means is that a fictional statement can be true and false. For instance, consider the statement "Killing an NPC in monitored space will earn you a crime state". According to Currie, this statement is true. What makes something true or false in a fiction, is its relation to the outside world and so what is important then, is what this relationship is.

Because fiction is a relational property, they are community based and “depend on the prevailing attitudes of the community, or of a subgroup of the community rather than the ideas of a single individual” (Currie 1990, 10).

For I take it that an act of joint authorship is exactly that: an act engaged in by more than one person rather than several distinct acts undertaken individually and patched together. (Currie 1990, 11)

The process of creating a fiction begins with the intention. It is not a singular intention however, but is a social enterprise. So maybe the reason that we do not call fake news, fiction, is because of the purposes and intent of fake news. It is intended to deceive rather than express true propositions. But if this is true, then why do we not consider that fiction is intended to deceive? Why does fiction have semantic properties such as truth whereas fake news does not? Currie (1990)

Owing to the fantastical nature of these accounts, it is highly probable that they are either misguided representations of some more familiar animal, or motivated by purposes other than truth. In the classical era, it is most likely the case that the Manticore is a confused representation of some other more familiar animal, while in the medieval period, the motivation for the representation lies outside of truth.

On this second point, in the 57th question of the 1st of the second part of the Summa Theologica, Thomas Aquinas defends the view of art as a form of right reason. There is a distinction here between the right reason for making objects, and the right reason for doing good actions. We should first focus on a central point here, what is important to both of these activities, namely the right use of one’s cognitive faculties. Therefore, the difference here lies in the aesthetic representation, whether of an action or object.

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